

AI is changing quick commerce

Zepto co-founder **Kaivalya Vohra** explains how

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Many of us use quick commerce platforms almost every day. But what many people are not aware of is the complex system working behind the scenes to make this possible. In an interaction with Digit, Zepto Co-Founder and President – Technology and Product, Kaivalya Vohra, explained how the company is using AI across its operations, why automation is about assisting people rather than replacing them, and how technology is helping everyone from customers to farmers.

AI customers never see

When people think of AI in apps, they usually imagine product recommendations or a chatbot answering customer questions. Zepto uses AI for those features, but that's only one part of the story. 'AI is already a meaningful tool in quick commerce because it supports better decisions across the customer and operating experience,' Vohra said.

According to him, AI works behind the scenes at almost every step of the shopping experience. 'At Zepto, AI is used in practical ways across the customer journey: making search more relevant, improving product discovery, powering recommendations and supporting customer queries,' he said.

AI helps understand customer intent

One of Zepto's biggest AI-powered tools is Zepto Atom, an in-house platform built for brands. Atom gives

brands useful insights into what customers are searching for, which categories are growing and what people are buying. 'It helps brands understand customer searches, category behaviour and purchase patterns on Zepto, so they can make more informed choices around product visibility, placement and campaign design,' Vohra explained. 'For a newer brand, that can mean reaching customers who are already looking for a relevant need, rather than relying only on broad-based advertising.'

AI is also helping farmers

The most interesting use of AI at Zepto isn't inside the app at all. It starts much earlier, on farms. India's agriculture has traditionally been supply-driven. Farmers usually decide what to grow based on weather conditions, previous crop cycles and local market trends. However, predicting what customers in cities will actually buy is much harder. This is where AI steps in.

Zepto's demand forecasting models analyse buying patterns across cities, neighbourhoods, seasons, festivals

and different price points. These insights help the company's sourcing teams understand future demand more accurately.

'For the farmer, the relevance is straightforward: better visibility into what is being bought, where demand is emerging, and the quantities required,' Vohra said. That supports more informed sourcing conversations, helps reduce avoidable mismatch between supply and demand, and can contribute to lower waste in the fresh-produce chain.'

Humans still make key decisions

Despite the growing role of automation, Vohra believes people are important. According to him, repetitive, high-volume and physically demanding tasks are ideal for automation because machines can perform them consistently. However, many jobs still require human judgment. Fresh produce is a good example. Assessing the quality and freshness of fruits and vegetables cannot always be reduced to a fixed set of rules. Similarly, handling unusual situations, solving operational problems and customer-related decisions still need people. 'The best operating model is not humans versus machines,' Vohra said. 'It is technology handling repeatable tasks at scale, while people focus on work that requires judgment, quality control and accountability.'

After spending time at Zepto's Mother Hub, one thing became clear to me. Quick commerce is much more than delivering an order quickly. **d**



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